appointments, viz. Platoon Commander, Section Commander, etc. The exercise appointments are in the line of fire; they not only have to prepare and give out the orders or briefings, whether for defence or attack or the day's patrol or ambush but also have to cajole their CMs into digging field defences, fetch water (usually uphill) in 30-litre *pakhals* (mule tanks) from a distant water-point, food collection and myriad other tasks. Everyone is so tired that it's difficult to get anyone on their feet, let alone get them to work. These appointments are usually rotated daily so that everyone gets a chance to show their worth. During the mountain warfare exercise, Capt Trikha, for some reason, kept me on as the Platoon Commander for the entire duration. When I remonstrated at this unfairness, he replied that he was doing so because I was the only one worth investing in, being the only Infantry optee in the entire Platoon. Be that as it may, the result was that by the end of the third or fourth day, I was literally sleeping standing up, fuelled almost entirely by drinking sweetened condensed milk straight from the tin. I still have a fondness for condensed milk, which trait my daughters too seem to have inherited.

The Choice of Arms is a major exercise carried out for the soon-to-be commissioned GCs. The vacancies likely to be accruing in each Arm and Service are promulgated and then one can make an informed choice, keeping in mind one's performance and the number of other people vying for those slots. For almost 200 vacancies for the Infantry, only thirty-odd GCs had opted for the Infantry as their first choice. This came as a shock to the establishment, as Infantry, the Queen of the Battle, was where one could expect the best prospects. This was not acceptable and the whole Academy, not just the third-termers, was called in for a motivational talk to be given by (then) Capt GD Bakshi. He was, and still is, a die-hard

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